

Assignment 5

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Unconsidered Metrics: SpO2

A vital sign descriptor for triage that was not included in the dataset is SpO2, the peripheral capillary oxygen saturation. This is the percentage of oxygenated hemoglobin out of the total functional hemoglobin in the blood. Normal SpO2 is 95-100% for all ages except newborns where 90-95% is more typical. Hypoxemia, a low oxygen concentration of oxygen in the blood, is clinically defined as a SpO2 of <90%.

It can be measured using a pulse oximeter, a non-invasive device that can be placed on the patient's finger or earlobe. Rapidly detecting the abnormal oxygen levels associated with hypoxemia is crucial as it may indicate life-threatening conditions such as, but not limited to, head injuries, drug overdose, active asthma attacks, pneumonia or immediate respiratory failure. Many of these conditions require immediate intervention; therefore, the recognition of abnormal blood oxygen levels is indispensable for rapid and accurate patient triage.

References

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